

CPC Adult Sunday Studies
Fall 2026

The Wonders of Communal Worship

Outline

1. Overall Theology of Worship

1. God-centered
2. Worship in general vs. Communal worship
3. Sabbath and Lord's Day

2. Distinctives of Communal Worship

1. Elements and Forms (Essentials and Styles)
2. God's presence - Communion vs. Decision
3. Trinitarian worship

3. Entering God's Presence: Adoration & Confession (Mvmts 1&2)

1. Biblical patterns
2. Holiness of God
3. Gospel arc

4. Hearing from Christ: Preaching of the Word (Mvmt 3)

1. What is a sermon?
2. Why preaching?
3. Guidelines and goals

5. Communing with Christ: Sacrament of the Lord's Supper (Mvmt 4)

1. Purpose and vision of the Supper
2. Who, when, and where
3. Relationship to the Word

6. Crowning Christ: Coronation and Benediction (Mvmt 5)

1. Christ's Kingship
2. Biblical Blessing
3. Review

Overall Theology of Worship

Read Psalm 96

1 | WHY WORSHIP?

Everything Starts with God! In the beginning is the end.

- **Who God is** - WCF 2.1-2 - "There is but one only, living, and true God, who is infinite in being and perfection, a most pure spirit, invisible, without body, parts, or passions; immutable, immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty, most wise, most holy, most free, most absolute; working all things according to the counsel of his own immutable and most righteous will, for his own glory; most loving, gracious, merciful, long-suffering, abundant in goodness and truth, forgiving iniquity, transgression, and sin; the rewarder of them that diligently seek him; and withal, most just, and terrible in his judgments, hating all sin, and who will by no means clear the guilty. 2. God hath all life, glory, goodness, blessedness, in and of himself; and is alone in and unto himself all-sufficient, not standing in need of any creatures which he hath made, nor deriving any glory from them, but only manifesting his own glory in, by, unto, and upon them. He is the alone fountain of all being, of whom, through whom, and to whom are all things; and hath most sovereign dominion over them, to do by them, for them, or upon them whatsoever himself pleaseth. In his sight all things are open and manifest, his knowledge is infinite, infallible, and independent upon the creature, so as nothing is to him contingent, or uncertain. He is most holy in all his counsels, in all his works, and in all his commands. To him is due from angels and men, and every other creature, whatsoever worship, service, or obedience he is pleased to require of them."
- **The Glory of God at the Center** - "We are all starved for the glory of God, not self. No one goes to the Grand Canyon to increase self-esteem. Why do we go? Because there is greater healing for the soul in beholding splendor than there is in beholding self... The point is this: We were made to know and treasure the glory of God above all things; and when we trade that treasure for images, everything is disordered. The sun of God's glory was made to shine at the center of the solar system of our soul. And when it does, all the planets of our life are held in their proper orbit. But when the sun is displaced, everything flies apart. The healing of the soul begins by restoring the glory of God to its flaming, all-attracting place at the center." - John Piper

- **The Purpose of Humanity** - WSC 1 - "Man's chief end is to glorify God, and to enjoy him forever."
- **The Purpose of All Creation** - *"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork." (Ps. 19.1)* [many more examples throughout Scripture!]
- **The Appropriateness of Praise** - "I never noticed that all enjoyment spontaneously overflows into praise. The world rings with praise — lovers praising their mistresses, readers their favorite poet, walkers praising the countryside, players praising their favorite game... Men spontaneously praise whatever they value, so they spontaneously urge us to join them in praising it: "Wasn't it glorious? Don't you think that magnificent?" Indeed we can't help doing it...because praise not merely expresses but completes the enjoyment; it is its appointed consummation." - C.S. Lewis

2 | WHO IS WORSHIP WITH? Worship in General vs. Communal Worship

Read these passages:

- *Exodus 3.12; 29.43-46* - the purpose of the Exodus was worship, to gather Israel as a worshipping community, set apart as a unique nation where God dwells. That will be the purpose of all creation in Rev. 21.3, as the whole earth becomes the promised Land.
- *1Ki. 8.27-30* - God himself was present in the Temple
- *Ephesians 2.19-22* - the church is the new temple, in Christ
- *Hebrews 12.18-24, 28-29* - We have come!
- *Revelation 5.11-14* - all creation!

Is all worship the same, though?

- *Col. 3.17* - "and whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."
- *1Cor. 10.31* - "So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God."
 - **Notice:** Both of these passages are in the context of how we should treat each other in the church, in our communal relationships as we live out being the temple of God.

- *And yet:* there's still a truth to the command to worship God all the time, do all things for his glory - your work, your thoughts, your walks, your relationships, your time alone, etc.
- *So what does the communal worship of God in the church include that "doing all to the glory of God" does not?*
 - **Who:** Gathered saints, ordered under the authority God has explicitly called for in the church. "Church" means "gathered assembly" or "called out ones" - you can't assemble by yourself!
 - **What:** Includes all the essentials of the gospel, explicitly instituted by God
 - **When:** Weekly Sabbath, as commanded by God
 - **Where:** Any agreed upon place that is judged to be wise and missional
 - **How:** By means of the promises of God in Christ by the Holy Spirit, promises which are given to the church communal, not the individual
 - **According to:** God's word, not human invention. Explicitly in God's word, as opposed to implied or derived from God's word, which is required for much of our lives elsewhere.
 - These are more casual ways to describe what we call the "**regulative principle**", which we'll cover next week. For example: notice all the lengths Paul goes to in 1Cor. 10-14 to regulate, call out, expose, condemn, and encourage in their communal worship.

Let us expand our vision of worship when we gather as a church! Far more than a time for a pep talk or therapeutic comfort (though not less), communal worship is nothing less than a foretaste of the kingdom of God on earth as it is in heaven, gathering with the saints around the world to do what we were made to do, according to the design and command of God.

3 | WHEN IS WORSHIP? The Sabbath and the Lord's Day

Read Exodus 20:8-11 and Hebrews 4:8-11

- The 4th Commandment is not obsolete! We fulfill it in Christ, just as Joshua led them to the promised Land, but they still observed a Sabbath, so too are Christians called to observe a Sabbath, that points us to the final rest day at Jesus' return. Jesus never breaks the Sabbath, only the rabbinical tradition that had risen around it. (See our previous class on the ten commandments)
- *Moved from the last day to the first day* - see John 20.19, 26; Acts 20.7; 1Cor. 16.1-2; Rev. 1.10 for worship on the Lord's Day. We start our week now with the grace of the new creation that defines our subsequent work, instead of waiting until the end of the week after our work.

Richard Gaffin on the Sabbath and Heb. 3.7-4.13 - "In the long passage Hebrews 3:7–4:13, he is intent on giving New Testament Christians a sense of their basic identity: they are **sojourners**; the church is a **pilgrim** people. He makes his point, in commenting on Psalm 95:7–11, by comparing the church to Israel in the wilderness. That **analogy has two sides**. On the one hand, just as Israel had been set free from slavery in Egypt, so believers have **already been released** from the guilt and power of sin. But, on the other hand, just as Israel in Sinai had not yet entered the land of Canaan, so we have **not yet attained** our salvation in its final fullness. An unthreatened, un-challenged (but not uncertain!) experience of salvation is still future for the church. This is why there are so many pronounced exhortations to persevere, not only in this passage, but throughout Hebrews....

"God wants us to view the final rest—the consummation order in store for God's redeemed children—as one grand, unending sabbath-rest. That suggests that the Sabbath day is an **eschatological sign**. In other words, our **weekly Sabbath-rest is a recurring pointer to that consummation**. Weekly Sabbath keeping is a sign that points to the end of history and to the ultimate fulfillment of all God's purposes for his creation....

"Our great privilege under the New Covenant is to **start each week with the Sabbath**. That's a sign—because of Jesus' resurrection on the first day of the week—not only that the new creation is '*ready to be revealed in the last time*' (1 Pet. 1:5), but also that our Lord Jesus Christ has actually already begun the new creation. Because we still look forward to the future consummation, when we will enter God's rest in perfection, we continue to have a weekly Sabbath in the New Testament. Because in Jesus Christ we have already entered God's rest in principle, we begin the week with the Sabbath. We already possess

“the promised Holy Spirit, who is a deposit guaranteeing our inheritance” (Eph. 1:14). The Lord’s Day is a weekly sign that salvation is not just a future hope, but a present possession.”

“To see the Sabbath in this light has significant implications not only for our attitude toward the Lord’s Day, but also for how we view ourselves and all of our activities as God’s servants. The weekly Sabbath is not just God’s provision so that we might have time to worship him (although it certainly is that). The rest itself—ceasing as much as possible from those activities that are appropriate on the other six days of the week—has positive meaning. The Lord’s Day is about worship because it is first of all **about the gospel**. It is a sign, a witness both to the church and to the watching world, that *‘you are not your own’* (1 Cor. 6:19). We are depending on God, not on ourselves, to provide for us. It is a sign that we do not trust in ourselves and our own efforts as fallen sons and daughters of Adam. We trust in the perfect righteousness of Christ, the last Adam. We trust in God’s faithfulness to his covenant promises to do for us what we are unable to do for ourselves.

“We obscure the meaning of the Lord’s Day if we detach it from the other six days of the week. The weekly cycle—which structures human existence in virtually every time and place—itself provides a kind of ‘philosophy of history.’ The pattern of six days of activity interrupted by one day of rest is a continuing reminder that human beings are not caught up in a meaningless flow of days, one after the other without end. **History has a beginning and an ending. We are heading toward final judgment and the consummation of all things.** Every time we remember the Sabbath day to keep it holy, it encourages us to “think big.” It reminds us of the truly large picture we are part of as God’s redeemed children. The weekly Sabbath is a God-given sign that our lives are not meaningless and without purpose. Every time we neglect to consecrate the Sabbath day to God, **we actually steal hope from ourselves.** Every time we fail to keep the day holy to God, we actually obscure our witness to the world of hope in Christ. Every Sabbath day is a gracious reminder that our “labor in the Lord is not in vain” (1 Cor. 15:58).” - Gaffin, “The Lord’s Day: A Sign of Hope”

Questions to consider in remembering the Sabbath

- How can I plan the rest of my week so that Sunday can be a day of worship and rest?
- How should I schedule travel and vacation? At least, go to church out of town!
- What activities should I (not) do on Sunday? Only extraordinary necessity (sickness, job, etc.) should prevent us from worship